teach him more than a thing or two about living in harmony with nature as opposed to merely salvaging what remained of it in the name of ‘sustainable’ development. It took him ages to even concede that there was something seriously amiss in his attitude to nature, by which time nature had started reacting to the plunder and devastation it had been subjected to.

Apart from wreaking unprecedented havoc on nature and wiping out native faith systems, the presence of the coloniser also had a direct bearing on native knowledge traditions because as stated earlier, such traditions were tied to the native faith, which was in turn rooted in nature. Native knowledge traditions were largely passed on through the generations orally, employing storytelling as a means of transmitting knowledge.[19] One of its objectives was to keep the knowledge within the community, so that it was accessible only to those who understood both its meaning and, importantly, its sanctity. This obviated the need for written records. However, the fundamental differences in their ontologies, coupled with the absence of written records, the importance given to the written word by the Christian coloniser, and the consequent treatment of oral traditions as apocryphal and ‘mythical’, may collectively explain the coloniser’s attitudes to indigenous onto-epistemological systems.

For all its expression of iconoclasm towards polytheistic and idol-worshipping indigenous communities, the religion of the European coloniser deifies its central scripture as the ‘Word of God’ given its revelatory treatment. Therefore, only that which was contained in their scripture or the Book was deemed to be true, making the colonisers the People of the Book. The expectation that every religion must have a ‘book’ as its sole authority that captured its tenets was essentially a Christian expectation, which was imposed on the onto-epistemological systems of native communities in order to delegitimise or Christianise their faiths. The absence of a ‘book’ not only rendered their faiths but also their entire history legendary and mythical in the eyes of the coloniser. Simply put, if the proof of the object of faith did not exist in writing, the object did not exist. The result was that instead of faith being treated as an experiential path to the divine, its validity had to be established in the eyes of a coloniser who was intent on judging indigenous faith systems on Christian European anvils of modernity and rationality.

The absence of written records made it more convenient for the coloniser to erase native histories after destroying or appropriating their sacred